

A rule is not advice. It is a price somebody has already paid, written down so that you do not have to pay it twice.

Seven rules were nailed to the door of a milking parlour in the first spring. Boil it. Don't shout. Two doors. By the third winter there were ninety-nine, and the man keeping the list had stopped writing down anything he had not watched cost somebody something.

Ninety-nine rules for staying alive after the outbreak. Each one carries the name of whoever paid for it, what keeping it buys you, and, in the paragraph that matters, what ignoring it costs.

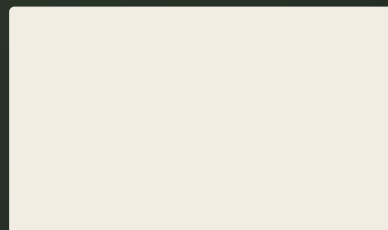
The rules contradict each other, and the book says so. One tells you to keep moving and never sleep twice in the same building. Another tells you to choose ground and hold it until the frost. One says take the stranger in. Another says never open the gate after dark, whatever you can hear on the other side of it. Both halves of every pair were written by people who were right where they stood.

“Never open a door you cannot shut behind you.”

Marta Ellison

WHAT IGNORING IT COSTS You will be in a room with one exit and a noise in it. The rule is not about doors. It is about the habit of counting your way out before you go in, which is the only habit that has kept anybody I know alive for three winters.

99 RULES · 11 CHAPTERS · 4 PARTS



Standing Orders

A SURVIVOR'S MANUAL

Standing Orders

Ninety-nine rules for staying alive after the outbreak, and what each one costs.

99 RULES · 11 CHAPTERS